INDIAN SHOOTING LEAGUE

(First half of 2026) *TBA**



Shooters may not be the most emotive lot to watch, but watching a shooting competition is akin to watching a battle of nerves unfold. The National Rifle Association of India is expected to assemble not only India's finest but even top-ranked international players for what is poised to be a first-of-its-kind league in the sport.



GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

(Dec. 13-24), *Mumbai*

The line-up of this team-based, gender-inclusive chess league includes the who's who of chess: from Viswanathan Anand and Koneru Humpy to world champion D. Gukesh and 11-year-old prodigy Faustino Oro, with the latter headlining GCL Contenders, a category that will feature amateur players alongside grandmasters and individual masters.



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alongside international talent were part of the week-long event which saw six teams play individual and double matches. With growing popularity in Indian metros, where courts are being built in gated communities, and tennis players succumbing to its charm, IPBL was a hit with viewers.

*TBA: to be announced



"WE HAVE MANY SHOOTERS WITH GREAT TALENT BUT WITH LITTLE INTERNATIONAL EXPOSURE. THIS LEAGUE GIVES THEM THE CHANCE TO COMPETE IN AN INTERNATIONAL EVENT

KALIKESH NARAYAN SINGH DEO
President, National Rifle Association of India

format. Indian Golf Premier League (IGPL) CEO Uttam Singh Mody is hoping to have a Ryder Cup-like atmosphere of team sports, where golf fans can root for teams. For Mody, the larger goal is to develop the ecosystem of an expensive pursuit. "We are involved in every aspect, from grassroots development and working with schools to building driving ranges and converting them into top academies," he adds. Apart from icons like Shiv Kapoor, Jyoti Randhawa and Jeev Milkha Singh, the IGPL will field a bunch of youngsters on the greens.

The impetus for the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), the body in charge of shooting in India, to start a league is different, for India already has an abundance of skilled seniors and gifted juniors. "Our shooting landscape is very competitive. You have a huge depth of talented shooters who haven't had international exposure," says NRAI president Kalikesh Narayan Singh Deo. "The league will enable us to see if they have technical capabilities and mental resilience. We are looking at it to provide us a talent pool for the next 12 years."

CLOSE ENCOUNTERS

Slated in the first half of 2026, the league enables India to flaunt its shooting clout by attracting high-ranked international talent. Seventy international athletes have signed up so far, in addition to 500-plus domestic applications. The league aims to put the viewer nearly in the shooters' shoes and capture the delicate side of shooting through the installation of biofeedback monitors that measure breath, and cameras that show precise lines of bullets.

Pickleball, the sport that started as a quirky cousin of tennis and has taken the world by storm as a fitness and lifestyle sport, is also going the league route. Though it has yet to make it to broadcast/ streaming networks, there's no denying pickleball's growing popularity in metros. "The league is the funnel; we hope that more people engage with and play pickleball and that it will be the biggest racket sport in country soon," says Sameer Pathak, president of the Indian Pickleball League, which concluded an event on December 7.

Sporting leagues that showcase great athletic skills are exciting, but that's not always enough to guarantee a win. For every success story like the Pro Kabaddi League, there are those, like the wrestling and badminton leagues, that didn't take off. However, that is not deterring stakeholders from investing in sports. For now, giving a cricket-guzzling public a taste of other sports is a worthy endeavour. Moreover, with India hosting the Commonwealth Games in 2030 and making a play for the 2036 Olympics, the leagues couldn't have come at a better time. ■